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GLOBAL CMO GROWTH COUNCIL AI PLAYBOOK



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Introduction

Chief marketing officers (CMOs) have always needed to master new technologies and skills to effectively drive growth. They built brands in the era of mass media, drove performance among digital channels, and embraced data, experience, and technology as marketing became more accountable and critical to the enterprise. Each wave expanded the CMO's responsibilities —

and raised expectations for how marketing is expected to deliver growth.

Now, artificial intelligence (AI) stands as the next powerful force they must master — bringing seemingly unlimited opportunities and risks.

Generative AI has the potential to reshape customer engagement, operating models, and decision-making across the enterprise. But this shift is faster, broader, and more complex. The playbook is still being written — and CMOs made it clear they shouldn't have to write it alone.

At the ANA Masters of Marketing, the Global CMO Growth Council identified AI as the defining leadership priority ahead and called for a shared, practical point of view built by CMOs, for CMOs. No more hype. Clarity. Direction. Action. So that's what we built.

ANA and Infosys Aster have partnered with the Global CMO Growth Council to create the AI Playbook, grounded in a year of collaboration with more than 50 CMOs and senior marketing leaders, along with insights from more than 125 ANA members. The result is practical guidance aligned to the growth priorities CMOs told us matter most.

This is the first iteration of a living resource designed to evolve alongside AI and the expanding responsibilities of marketing leadership.



systems now emerging behind it, extend that impact dramatically.

This playbook is designed to help CMOs navigate that reality. Its purpose is not to encourage experimentation for its own sake, but to help marketing leaders move from pilots to embedded, enterprise AI that delivers measurable business impact and builds trust with customers, employees, and regulators.

This AI playbook begins by examining the short- and long-term implications of AI across marketing, including data, technology, and measurement; brand, creativity, and media; B2B and small- to mid-sized companies; inclusive and sustainable marketing; and the talent and organizational model.

In the short term, AI drives efficiency, faster decision-making, and new ways of working. Over time, it reshapes how marketing organizations are structured and how value is measured and growth is generated.

Executive summary

AI is reshaping marketing faster and more broadly than previous waves of technology. For chief marketing officers, this moment goes beyond adopting new tools or improving productivity. It marks a structural shift in how marketing creates value, across data, technology, talent, creativity, governance, and the operating model itself.

Marketers have already proven AI's tactical value. Rules-based and deterministic AI systems have long supported measurement and personalization. Generative AI, and the agentic

The playbook addresses what's required to scale AI responsibly and effectively. It defines what enterprise AI readiness looks like, explains why data acts as both accelerator and constraint, shows how leading organizations move from experiments to embedded workflows, and outlines how governance and responsible AI practices enable rather than restrict innovation. It also highlights the role of AI literacy, upskilling, and change management in turning adoption into lasting organizational capabilities.

What follows is a practical guide grounded in what CMOs are doing today and where they expect value to emerge next.



Short- and long-term implications of AI in marketing

Short-term implications

Data

- **First-party data urgency:** With cookies being deprecated, CMOs are prioritizing first-party and consented data.
- **Data integration pressure:** Fragmented data systems reduce AI effectiveness. Without integration, AI outputs are unreliable.
- **Data quality concerns:** Poor hygiene, duplication, or bias in data can cause reputational risk in AI-driven campaigns.
- **Data as a gateway to value:** AI is evolving from simple automation to intelligent orchestration when data is leveraged effectively.

Long-term implications

Data

- **Insight generation and decision-making:** Enhanced strategy is expected to be the most popular AI use case in the next 12 months.
- **Dynamic, always-on data:** Ecosystems will continuously ingest behavioral and contextual data.
- **Data ethics as differentiator:** Transparency in data collection, usage, and consent becomes part of brand trust.
- **Synthetic data:** Brands increasingly use AI-generated datasets to train personalization engines while preserving privacy.
- **Data types:** CMOs focus on first-party data and consented data foundations.

Short-term implications

Technology

- **Tool explosion:** AI capabilities are bundled into standard marketing tools, reducing the need for specialized AI products and accelerating adoption across organizations.
- **Investment decisions:** First-party and consented data will take on immediate strategic importance, shaping MarTech investment decisions and platform selection.
- **Integration challenges:** Point solutions often don't integrate well with existing MarTech stacks, creating workflow friction.
- **Unifying factor:** Marketing platforms increasingly act as orchestration layers, using AI to connect data, content, and execution across previously siloed systems.

Long-term implications

Technology

- **Converged AI-first stacks:** MarTech evolves into integrated AI-native platforms, reducing reliance on patchwork tools.
- **Agentic marketing systems:** AI agents autonomously plan, buy, and execute campaigns within governance frameworks.
- **CMO-CIO partnership:** Technology strategy becomes inseparable from marketing strategy, elevating ITmarketing alignment.
- **New operating model:** AI will stop being an add-on and start rewriting [how agencies actually operate](#).
- **AI by default:** AI tools become standard marketing tools rather than specialized technologies.

Short-term implications

Measurement

- **Faster insights:** AI accelerates campaign analysis, enabling near-realtime optimization.
- **Return on investment (ROI) focus:** Early AI deployments emphasize cost savings and productivity.
- **Human in the loop:** Marketing teams must oversee outputs to prevent misleading metrics or biased conclusions.
- **Challenges to better measurement:** Data quality and governance will immediately constrain measurement improvements, since AI performance depends on [clean, connected, and well-managed data ecosystems](#).
- **Faster insights:** Real-time or near-real-time measurement will become more common, reducing reliance on periodic performance snapshots and static dashboards.

Long-term implications

Measurement

- **New value metrics:** Shift from impressions and click-through rates to AI-enabled measurements, such as trust, attention quality, and long-term customer lifetime value. These changes will help CMOs better understand AI's contribution to outcomes, including cross-platform attribution.
- **Predictive and prescriptive analytics:** Measurement systems forecast impact before campaigns launch and prescribe corrective actions.
- **Closed-loop systems:** Data, execution, and outcomes are seamlessly linked to enable continuous optimization.
- **Financial impact:** Outcome-based measurement will dominate budgeting and planning decisions, tightening the connection between marketing activity and business impact.

Short-term implications

Brand

- **Faster creative cycles:** AI accelerates content creation and testing, allowing brands to refine messaging, formats, and visuals in real time.
- **Smarter targeting:** Advanced algorithms enable deeper consumer insights, more precise audience segmentation, and personalized engagement based on behavioral and intent data.
- **Clearer measurement:** Improved attribution and performance visibility across channels increase accountability and optimize campaign spending.
- **Content quality risks:** Rapid automation raises the potential for off-brand or low-quality AI content, threatening consistency and brand equity.
- **Privacy and trust:** Rising data scrutiny intensifies the need for transparent, ethical AI use to maintain compliance and protect customer confidence.
- **Optimized search:** AI is changing how consumers discover and interact with brands. Brands must change and refine strategies for [AI-powered search](#) and recommendation systems.

Long-term implications

Brand

- **Deepened trust:** Privacy-safe efforts, such as clean rooms and synthetic data, strengthen customer trust and turn privacy into a brand differentiator.
- **Sustained personalization:** Robust, privacy-compliant data allows AI to deliver scalable, consistent personalization and experiences that build long-term customer relationships.
- **Brand consistency at scale:** As AI-generated content proliferates, governance becomes essential to maintain alignment and authenticity.
- **Creative augmentation:** AI evolves into a creative partner, amplifying human insights and originality, rather than replacing them.
- **Brand leadership narrative:** Companies that use AI responsibly position themselves as ethical innovators, reinforcing reputation and long-term brand equity.

Short-term implications

Creativity

- **Faster ideation cycles:** AI accelerates concept generation and iteration, enabling creative teams to test and refine more ideas in less time.
- **Enhanced personalization:** Generative tools tailor creative assets to individual preferences at scale, increasing engagement and campaign performance.
- **Lower production costs:** AI reduces dependency on manual design and copywriting for routine tasks, freeing budgets for higher-value creative work.
- **Human oversight:** Human review remains critical to ensure AI outputs reflect brand voice, emotional nuance, and authenticity.
- **Ethical and copyright concerns:** The growing use of AI-generated imagery and copy introduces new legal and ethical questions around ownership and originality.

Long-term implications

Creativity

- **Human-AI cocreation:** Creativity will become a hybrid discipline, where humans guide AI to amplify strategy, emotion, and storytelling.
- **Redefined creative roles:** Marketers, designers, and writers will evolve into AI directors — training, prompting, and curating machine-generated ideas to maintain originality and intent.
- **Strategic differentiation gap:** As AI tools become standard, competitive advantage will shift to brands that pair data-driven intelligence with cultural insight and creativity.
- **Creative governance frameworks:** Companies will establish formal guidelines for AI use, authorship, and ethics to ensure authenticity, compliance, and creative integrity. Brands can leverage AI to [inform and inspire](#), not replace creative thinking.
- **Cultural authenticity challenge:** Overreliance on AI risks homogenizing brand reputation; those that preserve human nuance and voice will stand apart.

Short-term implications

Media

- **Smarter media buying:** AI accelerates analysis of audience behavior and pricing signals, improving media planning, bidding precision, and ROI.
- **Real-time optimization:** Algorithms adjust spending, placement, and creative assets dynamically, enabling faster, datadriven responses to performance shifts.
- **Transparency concerns:** Opaque algorithms make decision-making harder to audit, prompting marketers to demand greater accountability from AI vendors.
- **Creative-media convergence:** AI's ability to link creative and placement data brings media and creative team closer together for more contextual storytelling.
- **Compliance pressures:** AI-driven targeting heightens scrutiny around data privacy and ethics, requiring stronger governance and partner oversight, particularly in relation to [intellectual property and misinformation](#).

Long-term implications

Media

- **Autonomous media planning:** AI will move beyond optimization to full orchestration, dynamically managing budgets, formats, and audiences with minimal human intervention.
- **Ecosystem integration:** Media, creative, and commerce systems will merge through shared AI models and unified data, eliminating silos and enabling better customer experiences.
- **Ethical media governance:** As automation expands, brands will need strong frameworks to ensure fairness, transparency, and accountability in AI-driven ad decisions.
- **Reduced intermediaries:** Automation will shrink the role of traditional media intermediaries, with brands increasingly managing AI-driven buying and analytics in-house.
- **Measurement reinvention:** AI will transform attribution, connecting exposure data with long-term customer value to deliver more predictive, actionable performance insights.

Short-term implications

AI for B2B

- **Campaign efficiency gains:** AI accelerates content creation, account-based marketing orchestration, and lead scoring and prioritization so CMOs can run [more campaigns with fewer resources](#).
- **Closer sales alignment:** AI tools develop insights that improve marketing-to-sales handoffs, shortening sales cycles and taking advantage of often narrow buying windows.
- **Experimentation culture:** Many businesses run pilots, such as campaign optimization or content generation, to build confidence, create minimum viable products, and prove value quickly.

Long-term implications

AI for B2B

- **From efficiency to growth:** AI shifts from cost savings to driving revenue through predictive engagement, customer lifetime value expansion, and upselling.
- **Account-level orchestration:** Multiple AI agents manage entire account journeys, from awareness through renewal, with minimal manual intervention.
- **Improved personalization:** AI enables messaging that adapts in real time to individual stakeholders within buying groups.
- **Competitive differentiation:** Businesses that scale AI responsibly stand out through faster response times, more relevant engagement, and stronger trust with enterprise buyers.

Short-term implications

AI for small to mid-sized companies

- **Improved targeting:** Predictive AI sharpens account selection and prioritization, helping sales teams focus on high-value opportunities.
- **Personalization at scale:** Early AI use enables more tailored messaging for industries, accounts, and buying groups, increasing engagement.
- **Leveling the playing field:** AI allows small teams to produce content, personalization, and basic analytics at a scale that previously required large budgets or agencies.
- **Brand risks:** Brand voice and authenticity will be an immediate risk since heavy reliance on AI-generated content can quickly lead SMC brands to sound generic or interchangeable if not carefully guided.

Long-term implications

AI for small to mid-sized companies

- **Size matters less:** AI will shift competitive advantage from company size to execution quality, as access to AI tools becomes commoditized and differentiation depends on how intelligently SMCs deploy them.
- **Measurement challenges:** Traditional marketing measurement frameworks will become insufficient for SMCs, as AI enables continuous, real-time optimization rather than periodic performance reviews.
- **Independence risks:** Dependence on AI platforms and vendors will deepen, raising long-term risks regarding technology lock-in, transparency, and loss of control over core marketing capabilities.
- **Greater flexibility:** SMC marketers will need durable, cross-disciplinary skills rather than narrow specialization — combining AI literacy, strategic thinking, creative judgment, and ethical oversight.

Short-term implications

AI for inclusive marketing

- **Broader representation in content:** AI tools can help marketers generate more diverse images, language, and scenarios — but only [if trained on inclusive datasets](#).
- **Bias risk management:** Early adoption requires vigilance to identify and correct biased outputs, such as stereotypes in imagery or exclusionary language.
- **Accessibility improvements:** Tools like AI-driven captions, translations, and adaptive interfaces expand reach to underrepresented audiences.
- **Need for governance:** Without guidelines, there's a risk of greenwashing or other missteps that damage credibility.

Long-term implications

AI for inclusive marketing

- **Equitable personalization:** As AI models mature, they will enable highly personalized experiences that reflect diverse identities, values, and needs. AI can also assist in developing product features that serve diverse populations.
- **Ethical data practices as brand differentiators:** Transparent, fair, and responsible data use becomes a competitive advantage with socially conscious consumers and regulators.
- **AI for sustainable operations:** Predictive analytics reduce resource use — from smarter targeting (fewer waste impressions) to optimizing carbon impact.
- **Inclusive design at scale:** AI democratizes marketing by making tools accessible to smaller organizations and underrepresented creators, amplifying diverse voices.
- **Trust as a market driver:** Brands that prove they use AI responsibly and sustainably win stronger loyalty, [brand love](#), [purchase intent](#), and long-term growth.

Short-term implications

AI for talent and marketing

- **Upskilling becomes urgent:** CMOs must quickly build [AI literacy](#) and [learning capabilities](#) for content generation, analytics, and personalization. A culture of adaptability and curiosity is increasingly valuable.
- **Shifts in roles and workflows:** Routine tasks (copywriting, reporting, A/B testing) are automated, freeing time for strategy, creativity, and customer engagement.
- **Experimentation mindset:** CMOs create a “safe to try, safe to fail” culture, piloting AI in low-risk projects to build confidence.
- **Cross-functional collaboration rises:** The CMO works more closely with the CIO on data and compliance to test and govern AI use cases and integration.
- **Anxiety about job security:** Many employees fear displacement, which requires improved CMO communication and change management.

Long-term implications

AI for talent and marketing

- **New talent profiles emerge:** Roles such as AI ethicist, prompt engineer, and marketing data strategist become core to the organization as workflows evolve. Durable skills like critical thinking, creativity, collaboration, and communication are essential.
- **Blurring boundaries with other functions:** Marketing, sales, and product teams integrate into unified “revenue organizations,” powered by shared AI tools.
- **Culture of continuous learning:** AI accelerates the need for lifelong learning, micro-certifications, and adaptive skill development across all levels.
- **The human touch:** With AI automating repetitive tasks, organizations can focus on diversity, creativity, strategic thinking, and human strengths that AI cannot replicate.
- **Leadership transformation:** CMOs evolve into orchestrators of AI-enabled ecosystems, balancing innovation with governance, ethics, and trust.
- **Human-AI collaboration models:** CMOs determine optimal division of labor between humans and AI.





Enterprise AI: What CMOs need to know

AI is changing marketing, but incremental gains from isolated use cases are not enough. To realize AI's full potential, CMOs must rethink what marketing does and how it operates. AI must move beyond being a [technology enabler](#) to become a driving force across the enterprise.

Enterprise AI represents the shift from isolated experimentation and point solutions to scaled, systemwide deployment across business functions. In this model, AI becomes a foundational capability for how the enterprise operates and creates value, with success dependent on readiness across strategy, governance, talent, data, and technology.

AI is truly integrated and available across the organization when it enables interoperability, continuous learning, and measurable improvements in business performance. Below are the essential elements of enterprise AI.

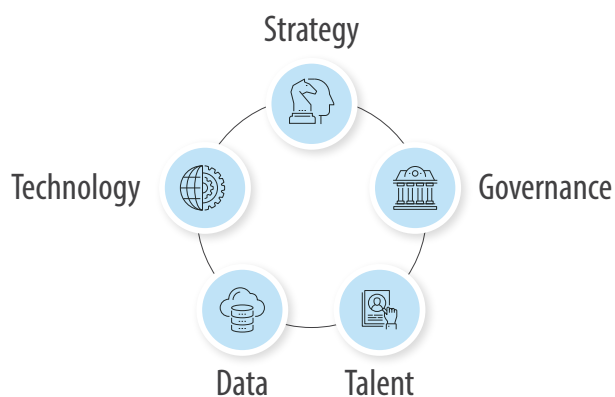
- **End-to-end integration:** Implementation of AI capabilities is large-scale and systemwide, rather than siloed, one off applications.
- **Interoperability:** AI enables cross-referencing and exploitation of varied data sources.
- **Reinforcing feedback:** AI learns over time and identifies optimization opportunities.
- **Widely available:** AI is widely available across the organization; colleagues in all departments use AI functionality.
- **Secure:** Risks have been identified and mitigated; partners have been vetted and approved.

- **Strong, clear, and disseminated governance:** AI governance has been developed, and colleagues are trained and aware of AI best practices.

Enterprise AI is the intended destination for many large, ambitious companies. Yet for most, it remains out of reach. Efforts are fragmented, and while value is beginning to emerge, it is not fully captured.

CMOs are learning that enterprise AI readiness is a complex, multidimensional challenge. The following framework outlines the five critical areas organizations must address as they move toward scalable AI adoption (Figure 1).

Figure 1. Five dimensions of AI readiness



Source: Infosys Knowledge Institute

- **Strategy:** Alignment with resources and policies; value of each use case confirmed before initiation.
- **Governance:** Rigorous processes established to reduce risks from AI, including ethical, brand, and legal risks.
- **Talent:** Employees trained, knowledgeable, and have a foundational understanding of AI.
- **Data:** Robustness and quality present across all data types.
- **Technology:** Foundational technology capabilities in place and readily accessible.

Few companies are confident they are ready across all five dimensions (2%), according to [Infosys research](#). While this finding looks bleak, marketing is uniquely positioned. Their AI integration is already broad and deep, with marketers using AI in nearly 60% of content creation, campaign management, and personalization efforts in 2024.

Marketing's AI use is increasingly effective. About half of the marketers surveyed in [CMO Radar 2024](#), who had deployed AI in marketing activities, reported achieving value.

While this progress is meaningful, it also highlights that many initiatives have yet to deliver their full potential.



Data is the accelerator ... and the brake

Once a supporting player that supplemented intuition, data now sits at the center of marketing. It drives precise targeting, personalization, and campaign optimization through analytics and AI. This shift was straightforward in theory — but in practice, it's one of the CMO's most persistent challenges.

The problem isn't scarcity; it's fragmentation. Most enterprises sit on years of customer data scattered across platforms, regions, and business units. The data is often inaccessible, locked in incompatible formats, or too unreliable to fuel advanced AI applications. Often manual processes are still needed.

*"Data is absolutely the cornerstone of AI success...
It gave us confidence."*

**Chief innovation officer
Financial services company**

"How do we ensure that the data in there is represented accurately?" asked the head of marketing data for a major technology company. "There is a huge element of human intelligence that's involved in scrutinizing it."

Without [unified architecture and clear data ownership](#), marketing AI struggles to learn, adapt, and act at scale. More than half of marketing leaders told us that data challenges — either privacy and security or maturity and integration — are among the most significant obstacles holding them back from successful AI implementations.

AI built on a solid foundation

CMOs have described data as marketing's "engine." Clean, unified, and well-governed data underpins everything from personalization to automation and campaign measurement. Yet many organizations still treat data management as a technical task rather than a strategic capability.

The right data — in the right place, at the right time — fuels innovation and enables inclusive, evidence-based marketing, ensuring that decisions reflect real customer needs instead of reflecting outdated assumptions or biased datasets.

A strong data foundation is the critical first step toward realizing value from AI marketing investments. Companies with unified data platforms or centralized data storage, robust data governance, and integrated MarTech stacks are more likely to [generate business value from AI marketing](#) initiatives.

Figure 2 on the next page is a checklist for CMOs to understand the strengths and weaknesses of their data foundation. With a strong data foundation, marketing leaders can scale AI confidently, using engagement data, customer insights, and feedback loops to deliver content that resonates and evolves with audiences, rather than merely targeting them.

The data challenges

Foster collaboration

Solving data challenges is not solely a marketing responsibility; it requires close partnership with

IT, data, and compliance teams. Marketers are increasingly part of integrated product groups that align data, technology, and business objectives from the outset. This collaboration now extends to legal, compliance, and human resources as organizations embrace citizen development and broader AI literacy.

As AI adoption accelerates, connecting and governing data across platforms will determine how quickly marketing teams can act on reliable insights.

"If you can't connect the different data points together to consumers so that you have a complete view... anything that sits on top of that from an analytic perspective, it's not going to be accurate."

Marketing leader
Information technology company

Many CMOs emphasize working closely with the chief data officer to ensure consumer and operator data is clean, organized, and dependable, forming the basis for scalable AI initiatives. At the same time, they caution against waiting for "perfect" data. The greater risk lies in inaction. Start with what exists, iterate, and improve data quality over time.

Establish robust governance practices

Responsible AI and data governance are non-negotiable, especially in regulated industries. CMOs are setting up formal governance committees, developing trustworthy AI principles, and working closely with legal and compliance to review all content and data use.

Figure 2. A data foundation evaluation checklist

 Data attribute	 Strong data foundation	 Weak data foundation
Data storage	Centralized data storage	Fragmented, siloed data storage
Data platform	Unified data platform	Disconnected, incompatible systems
AI alignment	Support for specific AI use cases	Lack of alignment between data and AI needs
Data quality	High-quality, accurate data	Inconsistent, error-prone, or outdated data
Data governance	Data governance integrated into architecture	Ad hoc or absent governance; compliance as afterthought
Data access	Real-time or near-real-time data access	Batch updates with long delays
Data standards	Standardized data formats and taxonomies	Incompatible formats and inconsistent definitions
Security and privacy	Strong data security and privacy controls	Weak security, exposure to breaches, compliance risks
Scalability	Scalable infrastructure for growth	Rigid systems that cannot adapt to new demands
Accessibility	Cross-functional data accessibility	Departmental ownership and restricted access
Ownership and accountability	Clear data ownership and accountability	Unclear responsibilities and lack of accountability
Analytics and AI	Advanced analytics and AI integration	Limited tools; reliance on manual reporting
Metadata and documentation	Robust metadata and documentation	Missing metadata; black box data sources
Monitoring and improvement	Continuous monitoring and improvement	"Set it and forget it" approach; neglected maintenance

Source: Infosys Knowledge Institute

This includes creating clear guidelines for what data can be used and how it is processed to ensure that privacy, security, and ethical standards are met.

Many organizations are also investing in ongoing training and awareness to ensure that their

employees understand both the power and the risks of AI and data use. Marketing leaders see AI governance as a strategic enabler for innovation and long-term value creation.

But the current AI governance can't be static; the opportunities and risks are ever-changing.

Use AI to clean and structure data

Marketers are now using AI to help solve data challenges, applying AI tools to clean, structure, and make sense of large, messy datasets. Others are experimenting with AI-powered data discovery, ontology, and taxonomy tools to make data more usable for both humans and AI agents.

“When you marry that up with external data sources, the richness of the data is something the human mind can't possibly comprehend,” said a chief growth officer for a leading European consumer goods company. “These are things that really disrupt and change the game for us.”

The goal is to move from “dirty data” and silos to actionable insights that drive business outcomes. Then, CMOs can shift from leaning on historical data to acting on predictive insights.

Align strategy with business objectives

CMOs stress that data strategy must be tightly aligned with business goals and customer experience. This means defining clear use cases, focusing on metrics that matter — not just vanity key performance indicators — and ensuring that data and AI are used to deliver relevant, personalized, and valuable experiences.

Marketers are encouraged to take ownership of the “data conversation,” drive innovation, and

ensure that data and AI are always in service of the brand promise and customer trust. “Let’s focus on the problem before we jump to AI,” one marketing leader for an automotive company said. “Let’s focus on how we are going to measure success. Ninety percent of the problem lies in that fact.”

Question traditional practices

Just because something was always done one way doesn't mean it should always be done that way. Data clean rooms and synthetic data together offer marketers a powerful path to insights without compromising privacy — or when existing data is fragmented across platforms.

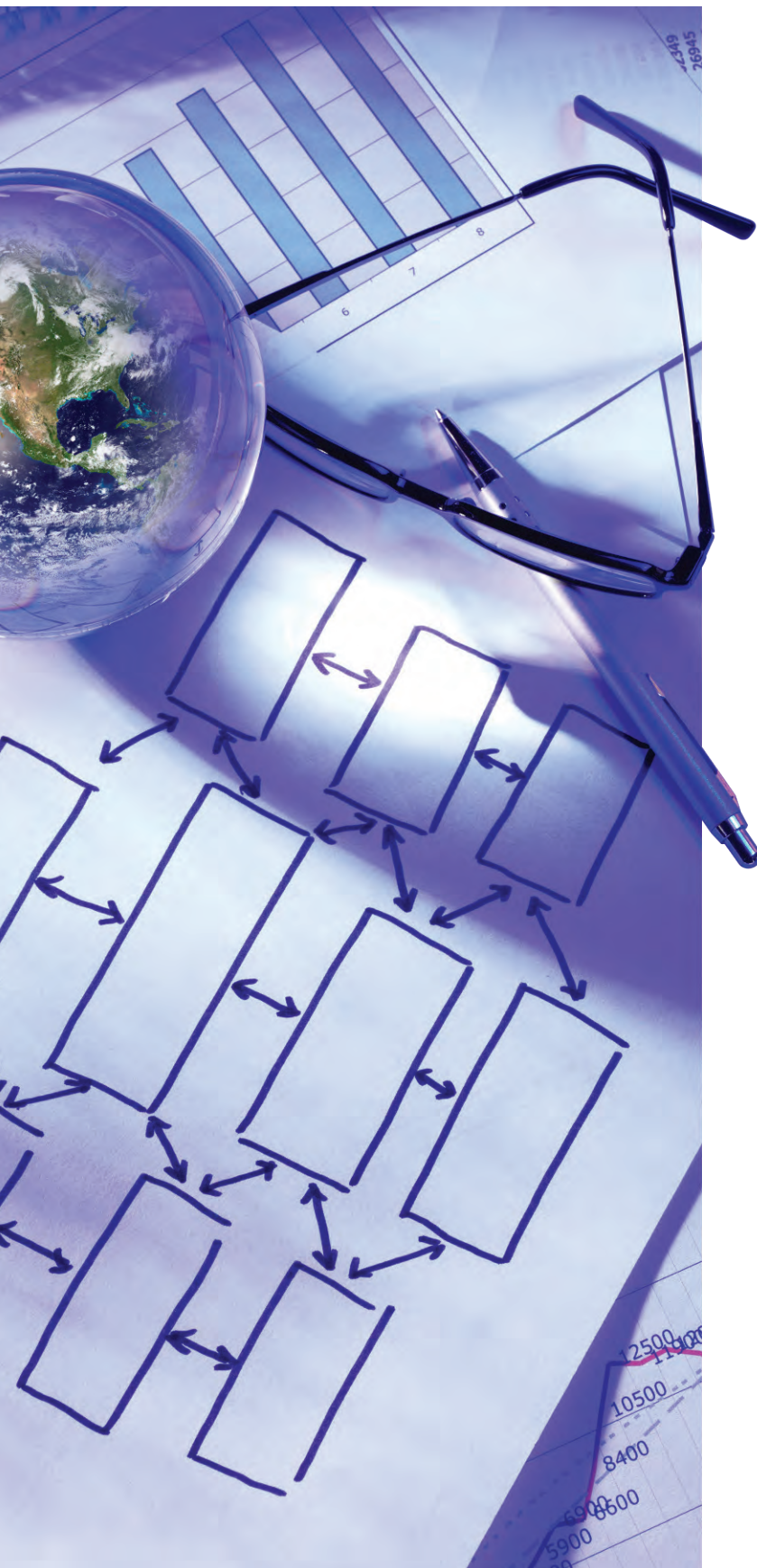
Clean rooms provide secure, compliant environments where brands and partners can analyze and match anonymized datasets without exposing personal information. This collaborative approach is important as organizations seek to open up systems with APIs and enable them to collaborate in real time while still respecting privacy and regulatory boundaries.

Synthetic data, artificially generated datasets that mirror real-world patterns, allows testing, modeling, and AI training without using sensitive customer records. This enhances an organization's efforts to encourage experimentation and develop test and learn environments.

Takeaways

- **Prioritize your data foundation:** Unified data platforms and centralized governance are foundational for AI-driven marketing.
- **Confront your biggest hurdles:** Data integration is the biggest current and future challenge; overcoming it unlocks personalization, efficiency, and business value.
- **Prioritize ethics:** Responsible AI and data privacy are not optional; they are critical for trust, compliance, and long-term success.
- **Balance the positive and negative:** AI amplifies both the value and the risks of data. Organizations must invest in both technology and change management to realize the benefits.





From AI pilots to embedded marketing workflows

AI experimentation has given marketing leaders valuable lessons, but pilots alone don't transform performance. The next stage is about converting early wins into consistent, scalable impact. The shift demands structure, measurement, and collaboration — and not just technical skills.

The most effective approach

Marketers across industries are finding that starting with a minimum viable product (MVP) is the most effective way to experiment with AI and move past “pilot purgatory.” An MVP provides a controlled, low-risk environment to test tools and use cases, deliver quick wins, and demonstrate tangible results before larger investments.

Piloting AI in focused projects, such as content generation, campaign planning, or analytics, helps teams gather feedback, refine processes, and build confidence in both the technology and their ability to manage it.

A strong MVP approach offers three main advantages:

- **Risk management:** Test AI in a controlled setting, minimizing exposure and avoiding costly missteps. Those with sufficient resources should create a separate testing facility within the marketing organization to evaluate tools and use cases.
- **Proof of value:** Demonstrate measurable business outcomes, such as time savings,

stronger personalization, or higher campaign ROI. Marketers should focus on the problem first, and only then determine how AI might benefit.

- **Cultural adoption:** Build organizational confidence by giving teams a safe space to experiment, upskill, and collaborate.

MVPs also help manage change. Controlled pilots address concerns about data quality, compliance, and human oversight while allowing workflows to adapt naturally.

"There are literally infinite uses of AI and what we're doing in marketing is putting it to work in as many places as we possibly can to test and learn."

**Chief brand officer
Technology company**

As teams see results, they can scale what works, adjust what doesn't, and ensure solutions align with business needs rather than hype.

Ultimately, the MVP approach provides a pragmatic way to navigate the complexity of AI adoption. By starting small, tracking results, and scaling thoughtfully, organizations move fast, learn quickly, and create sustainable business value without overcommitting to untested technology.

How to operationalize AI

Launching AI pilots successfully requires discipline and focus. Too often, organizations get caught up in hype or spread resources thin across too many initiatives.

A structured approach helps CMOs and their teams move quickly while minimizing risk, proving value, and laying the groundwork for a transition to enterprise AI.

These best practices can guide marketing leaders as they design and execute AI pilots:

- **Start with a clear business problem:** Choose use cases aligned with strategic priorities and measurable outcomes. Prioritize pilots that address high-impact challenges, such as automating content review or optimizing demand generation.
- **Measure and iterate:** Define KPIs for each pilot, such as content production speed, engagement rates, or cost per lead. Use these metrics to evaluate success, gather feedback, and refine the approach. The [Infosys AI Business Value Radar](#) shows that organizations that measure outcomes and iterate consistently are more likely to capture business value from AI.
- **Build cross-functional teams:** Involve marketing, IT, data science, and compliance from the start. One effective task force includes product owners, data leads, and brand experts to ensure pilots are robust, compliant, and scalable.
- **Document and share learnings:** Establish a feedback loop to capture lessons, challenges, and best practices. Sharing knowledge accelerates organizational learning and prevents repeated mistakes as adoption expands.
- **Plan for scale early:** Design pilots with growth in mind. Modular architectures and cloud platforms help support larger data volumes and user demand as AI adoption accelerates.

Takeaways

- **Start small but design for scale:** MVPs are essential but always plan for how successful pilots will be embedded and scaled.
- **Operationalize, don't isolate:** AI must become part of the marketing muscle memory — embedded in workflows, not just run as experiments.
- **Measure and iterate:** Establish clear KPIs for each pilot, track progress, and refine based on results to ensure continuous improvement.
- **Plan for scale early:** Design pilots with modular, flexible architectures that support future growth and integration.
- **Balance speed with discipline:** Move quickly to capture early gains while maintaining the rigor needed for sustainable, enterprisewide adoption.





Responsible AI for growth

As AI becomes integral to marketing, governance and responsible practices are not just safeguards — they are enablers of value creation.

A well-defined governance framework brings structure and accountability to how AI systems are developed, deployed, and monitored. This governance framework even helps create ethical boundaries, assisting CMOs in determining where AI should not be deployed despite technical capabilities.

Within that structure is the foundation for sustainable growth, competitive advantage, and even innovation.

"I think it's a false choice ... governance can be an enabler for innovation."

**Marketing lead
Government organization**

As AI becomes deeply embedded in marketing organizations, the risks and responsibilities multiply. Data privacy, regulatory compliance, brand safety, and ethical use have become board-level concerns for every CMO.

Without clear guardrails, AI can quickly turn into a source of reputational, legal, and operational risk, which erodes trust with customers, partners, and regulators.

When governance is done well, it enables AI to scale safely and confidently. Responsible AI is not only about managing risk, it empowers businesses to move faster, with greater assurance and across the enterprise (Figure 3).

Figure 3. Elements of robust AI governance

Practice	Description
Clear policies and frameworks	Formal AI policies covering data privacy, model transparency, explainability, human oversight
Centralized oversight and accountability	Centralized AI governance body or integrated council reviews and updates policies; council includes marketing, IT, legal, compliance, and data science
Human-in-the-loop controls	Human review at key decision points for content, campaign approvals, customer-facing outputs; ensures AI assets align with brand values, regulatory requirements
Data privacy and security by design	AI systems designed with privacy and security, robust data governance, and consent management; regular audits of data flows and model outputs to address GDPR, CCPA, and other regulations
Continuous monitoring and auditing	Ongoing monitoring of AI performance, bias, compliance; automated alerts, regular audits; catches issues early, ensures alignment with business and ethical standards

Source: Infosys Knowledge Institute

Case studies

- L'Oréal:** Developed its “[responsible framework for trustworthy AI](#),” with seven principles that include human oversight, transparency, data protection, and accountability. Internal governance bodies verify that the principles are followed in practice.
- Infosys Aster:** Embeds responsible AI into every client engagement, with centralized governance, human-in-the-loop controls, and automated monitoring. For example, in [content supply chain solutions](#), AI-generated assets are always reviewed by brand and compliance teams before they go for publication.
- IT company:** Launched an AI governance training program and best practice workshops for all marketing employees, ensuring everyone understands their role in responsible AI use and compliance.

Four ways governance enables scale

- 1. Accelerates adoption:** With clear guardrails, teams know what's allowed, what needs review, and how to escalate concerns. This reduces bottlenecks and builds confidence across the organization.
- 2. Reduces risk:** Centralized governance and automated monitoring prevent costly mistakes and reputational damage.
- 3. Builds trust:** Customers, partners, and regulators are more likely to trust brands that can demonstrate responsible AI practices and transparent decision-making.
- 4. Unlocks innovation:** When marketers know the rules, they're empowered to experiment and innovate — confident that their AI initiatives are safe and compliant.

Takeaways

- **Use responsible practices to scale AI:** Without strong governance, AI cannot be deployed safely or sustainably in marketing.
- **Drive consistency with centralized oversight:** A unified governance council ensures policies are applied consistently across teams and projects.
- **Prioritize human judgment:** Embedding human-in-the-loop review at critical points protects brand values and regulatory compliance.
- **Use AI to create trust:** Brands that lead in responsible AI earn customer confidence, regulatory approval, and long-term competitive advantage.



The human element of AI

Many marketers now work with AI tools for content creation, analytics, personalization, and campaign optimization. Yet not enough fully understand how these systems function or how to interpret their outputs responsibly. The task will only get harder as new AI tools reach the market. Training builds the confidence and creativity needed to innovate with AI.

"For us, it's not when to include the human because they're always there . . . it's just to what extent and how."

**Chief growth officer
Consumer goods company**

Brands should view AI as a powerful tool to enhance both efficiency and creativity but not as a replacement for human insight and emotional connection. Human strategic thinking remains crucial. As [one marketing expert noted](#), "AI can't address the emotional connection that your customers have with your brand."

Why change management matters

As AI embeds further into workflows, the challenge shifts from technology to people. Scaling AI is more than deploying tools. CMOs must build an organization where everyone, not just data scientists, is confident using AI, understands its limits, and applies it responsibly. AI is only as powerful as the people who use it — and how they are allowed to use it. As the CMO of a global life sciences company explained, "AI isn't just a toolset. It's reshaping how we work and how we structure the organization."

The AI literacy foundation

AI literacy means every marketer — regardless of role — is able to:

- **Apply AI tools with confidence** in daily work, from content generation to campaign optimization and analytics.
- **Recognize limitations and risks**, including bias, hallucinations, and privacy concerns.
- **Escalate appropriately** — knowing when to involve human review or compliance oversight.
- **Communicate effectively** about AI with colleagues, partners, and customers.

AI is no longer the sole domain of data scientists. To scale effectively, organizations need every marketer to be comfortable with AI tools, aware

"We're focusing on upskilling, reverse mentoring, and helping employees move from fear to confidence."

**Customer experience leader
Healthcare company**

of their limitations, and capable of using them responsibly. Building this confidence ensures that AI becomes a practical, everyday part of marketing rather than a specialized function siloed in technical teams.

AI literacy is a prerequisite for responsible AI. Without a broad understanding across the organization, companies risk misusing the technology, failing to meet compliance standards, and eroding trust with customers and regulators. By prioritizing AI literacy, leaders create the foundation for responsible adoption and long-term success.

Figure 4. Training types

 Training Type	 Approach
Formal programs	AI governance training, best-practice workshops, and microlearning modules for all marketing employees
Peer learning and reverse mentoring	Reverse mentoring, where digital natives coach experienced marketers on AI tools, along with peer learning sessions to share tips and lessons learned
Hackathons and hands-on labs	AI hackathons for marketing teams that make upskilling enjoyable, collaborative, and practical

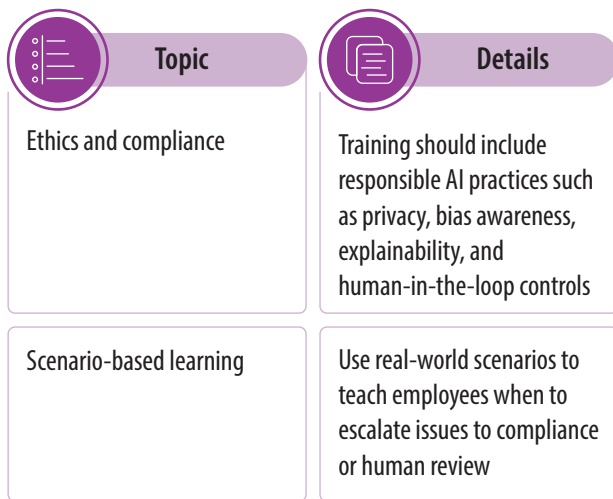
Source: Infosys Knowledge Institute

Figure 5. Make AI training accessible

 Method	 Definition
Microlearning	Fifteen-minute on-demand micro-courses that build foundational AI knowledge quickly and flexibly
Brown-bag sessions	Regular sessions to demo new tools, showcase use cases, and answer questions in an informal setting
Onboarding and certification	New hires receive AI onboarding, and organizations provide internal certifications to recognize and validate AI fluency

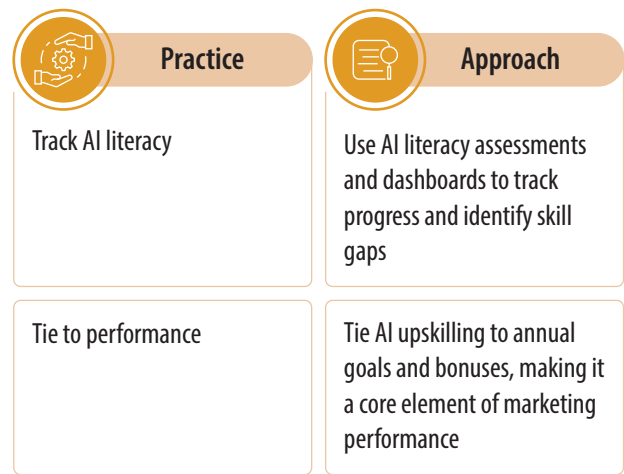
Source: Infosys Knowledge Institute

Figure 6. Focus on responsible use



Source: Infosys Knowledge Institute

Figure 7. Track and incentivize progress



Source: Infosys Knowledge Institute

Takeaways

- **Include everyone in AI upskilling:** AI literacy should extend beyond data scientists. Every marketer needs the skills to use AI effectively.
- **Focus on responsible use:** Training must address not only how to use AI but also how to apply it ethically and safely.
- **Understand the change management journey:** Leadership, clear communication, and a culture of experimentation are crucial to scaling AI successfully.
- **Measure and reward progress:** Track literacy, celebrate early adopters, and link upskilling achievements to performance goals.



The CMO's untapped AI value

As AI moves from experimentation to everyday use, marketers now face a pivotal question: how to maximize the value of their investments. The focus now shifts from adoption to optimization — ensuring that AI delivers measurable business outcomes across creativity, efficiency, and growth.

The next steps are about turning AI from a promising capability into a sustained competitive advantage.

Why prioritization matters

As AI experimentation gives way to scaled deployment, leading marketing organizations are moving beyond “shiny object” pilots. The focus must now shift to AI applications that solve real business problems, can be replicated, and deliver measurable impact.

Most organizations are still learning how to translate experimentation into value at scale. The difference between success and failure lies in identifying use cases that are both viable and valuable.

Human-facing use cases, such as marketing, customer service, and sales, have historically delivered fewer positive outcomes than those in IT or operations. Yet, as investment and organizational maturity grow, success rates rise. The imperative now is to double down on proven use cases and scale them with discipline and focus (Figure 8).

To create repeatable impact

Clear links to business objectives

- **Tackle high-priority challenges:** Choose use cases that directly address pressing needs such as improving conversion, reducing churn, or increasing campaign ROI.
- **Focus on proven applications:** Examples here include marketing asset creation, campaign optimization, and customer segmentation.

Measurable ROI

Prioritize trackable impact: Select applications where success can be measured through clear metrics — revenue uplift, cost savings, time-to-market, or customer satisfaction.

Repeatability and scalability

Think beyond one-off pilots: Focus on use cases that can be applied across multiple campaigns, products, or business units.

Figure 8. High-impact, repeatable AI use cases in marketing

Use case	Description	Repeatability-measurability
Marketing asset creation	AI-powered tools that generate campaign assets, such as images, copy, and video — quickly and at scale	Repeatable across campaigns, products, and regions
Chatbots and automated customer service	AI assistants that handle routine customer queries, freeing human agents to focus on more complex issues	Proven to reduce costs and improve customer satisfaction
Campaign analytics and optimization	AI-driven analysis of campaign performance, providing recommendations for budget allocation, creative optimization, and channel mix	Repeatable and measurable for every campaign
Customer segmentation and personalization	AI models that identify high-value customer segments and deliver personalized experiences at scale	Requires good data but delivers measurable uplift in engagement and conversion
Agentic AI orchestration	Deploy multiple AI agents to automate end-to-end marketing processes, from campaign planning and execution to reporting	High viability and transformational potential as organizations mature

Source: Infosys Knowledge Institute

Invest in maturity: Established use cases such as chatbots, campaign analytics, and creative asset generation often deliver repeatable, scalable value.

Operational fit

Integrate seamlessly: Pursue AI use cases that align with existing marketing workflows and are supported by the right data, technology, and talent.

Evolve the operating model: Scaling AI successfully demands changes to data structures, governance, and workforce engagement.

Four steps to prioritize use cases

Step 1: Map use cases to business value and viability: Use a simple matrix to score potential use cases by business impact (e.g., revenue, efficiency, customer experience) and viability (e.g., data readiness, technical feasibility,

user acceptance). High viability use cases such as marketing asset creation, chatbots, and campaign analytics are strong starting points.

Step 2: Start with proven, low-effort use cases: Mature applications like repurposing content and rapid experimentation offer early wins. They require less transformation, demand lower investment, and are more likely to succeed.

Step 3: Invest in transformational opportunities: As organizational maturity grows, shift resources toward transformational use cases that require changes to operating models and data architecture. Examples include AI-driven product launches, advanced personalization, and agentic AI orchestration. These initiatives can deliver outsized business value and competitive differentiation.

Step 4: Measure, iterate, and scale: Track results with clear metrics, capture feedback, and refine solutions. Scale use cases that deliver clear value, and sunset those that fall short.

Takeaways

- **Prioritize high-value use cases:** Select applications with clear business impact and measurable ROI.
- **Focus on scalability:** Invest in repeatable, scalable solutions rather than one-off pilots.
- **Balance short- and long-term bets:**

Pursue quick wins to build momentum while also investing in transformational use cases for lasting differentiation.

- **Measure, refine, and scale:** Track outcomes, iterate based on results, and expand the AI solutions that deliver tangible value.

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